

AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Associate (SAA-C03)

Exam Essentials

- **Format:** 65 questions (multiple choice and multiple response) in 130 minutes ([Amazon Web Services, Inc.](#), [kodekloud.com](#))
- **Passing Score:** Scaled between 100–1000, with 720 as the minimum passing score ([AWS Static](#), [kodekloud.com](#))
- **Weightings** (domain-wise distribution):
 - Design Secure Architectures — **30%**
 - Resilient Architectures — **26%**
 - High-Performing Architectures — **24%**
 - Cost-Optimized Architectures — **20%** ([AWS Static](#), [kodekloud.com](#))

Domain Breakdown & Key Topics

1. Design Secure Architectures (~30%)

- **Task Areas:**
 - Secure access management (IAM, Identity Center/SAML, cross-account roles, ACPs)
 - Securing workloads (VPC architecture, security groups, ACLs, NAT Gateways, Shield, WAF, Secrets Manager, GuardDuty, Macie, Cognito)
 - Data security (encryption at rest and in transit, KMS, ACM, key rotation, data governance, backups, lifecycle policies)
- **Key Skills:**
 - Apply least privilege, MFA, root user protection
 - Design multi-account security using Control Tower and SCPs
 - Implement VPC segmentation, external access securely, and integrate security services properly
 - Apply encryption strategies and key management practices ([AWS Static](#))

2. Design Resilient Architectures (~26%)

- **Task Areas:**
 - Building scalable, loosely coupled architectures: microservices, REST APIs, SQS, event-driven design, Lambda, Fargate, caching, load balancing, containers, Edge (CDN)
 - Ensuring high availability and fault tolerance: multi-AZ/region deployments, Route 53, DR strategies (pilot light, warm standby, active-active, RTO/RPO), immutable infrastructure, quotas, X-Ray
- **Key Skills:**
 - Design decoupled, scalable architectures using appropriate AWS services
 - Choose resilience mechanisms (failover, backups, DR plans)
 - Mitigate single points of failure and ensure data durability ([AWS Static](#))

3. Design High-Performing Architectures (~24%)

- **Task Areas:**
 - Storage: S3, EFS, EBS characteristics, hybrid storage patterns
 - Compute: EC2 types, Lambda, Auto Scaling, Fargate, batch processing, decoupling workloads
 - Databases: RDS vs. Aurora vs. DynamoDB, read replicas, caching strategies, capacity planning, proxies
 - Networking: CloudFront, Global Accelerator, subnetting, routing, VPN/Direct Connect, load balancers
 - Data ingestion & transformation: Kinesis, Glue, Athena, Lake Formation, QuickSight, DataSync, EMR, data lakes, streaming, visualization
- **Key Skills:**
 - Select services and configurations to meet performance and scalability demands
 - Design compute and DB solutions with optimal capacity, caching, and replication
 - Architect network solutions for low latency and throughput
 - Implement data pipelines and transformation strategies efficiently ([AWS Static](#))

4. Design Cost-Optimized Architectures (~20%)

- **Task Areas:**

- Storage: lifecycle policies, tiering, cost tools (Cost Explorer, Budgets), S3, EBS, FSx, storage migration (DataSync, Transfer Family)
- Compute: EC2 types, Savings Plans, Reserved/Spot Instances, hibernation, containers, serverless, Edge compute
- Databases: engine selection, snapshots, retention, serverless vs. provisioned
- Networking: optimizing transfer costs, cost visibility tools, multi-account billing
- **Key Skills:**
 - Design storage with efficiency and tiered costs
 - Choose cost-saving compute options and instance strategies
 - Optimize DB setup for cost vs. performance
 - Use AWS cost management tools and design networks with cost in mind ([AWS Static](#))

Recommended Study Plan & Resources

1. **Start with the Official Exam Guide (SAA-C03)** — understand domains, weightings, and task statements thoroughly ([AWS Static](#), [Tutorials Dojo](#))
2. **AWS Skill Builder & Training** — use AWS' digital courses, practice question sets, labs, and full-length practice exams ([Amazon Web Services, Inc.](#))
3. **Whitepapers & Documentation** — dive into AWS Well-Architected Framework and services documentation via "Architecting on AWS" and related whitepapers ([AWS Static](#), [Tutorials Dojo](#))
4. **Practice Exams & Cheat Sheets** — leverage resources like Tutorials Dojo or Whizlabs for mock tests and condensed cheat-sheets ([Medium](#), [Digital Cloud Training](#), [Whizlabs](#))
5. **Hands-on Labs** — reinforce learning with AWS Builder Labs, Cloud Quest, or real project practice on AWS ([Amazon Web Services, Inc.](#))
6. **Create a Study Schedule**
 - For example:
 - Days 1–2: Review exam blueprint
 - Days 3–10: Deep-dive into each domain with alternating study and mock quizzes
 - Days 11–14: Final review + full-length mock exams and weak area reinforcement ([Medium](#))

Summary Table: Domain to Key Focus & Study Tips

Domain	Weight	Key Focus Areas
Secure Architectures	30%	IAM, encryption, VPC, WAF, GuardDuty, key management
Resilient Architectures	26%	DR strategies, multi-AZ/regional design, decoupling, high availability
High-Performing Architectures	24%	Storage, compute scaling, DB tuning, networking, data pipelines
Cost-Optimized Architectures	20%	Lifecycle policies, cost tools, resource types, purchase options, budget tracking